



SHEN KUO

Chinese astronomer and mathematician
1031–1095



Kuo's books are the first to mention magnetic compasses. He wrote that they don't point to the true North (a fixed point) but to a magnetic North Pole.

Specialized areas of science—such as geology, zoology, and paleontology—are a recent invention. A thousand years ago, great thinkers didn't divide up knowledge in this way. They studied anything that interested them—and Shen Kuo was interested in everything!

Kuo began his career working for the Chinese government and excelled at every task he was given. For example, after solving an engineering problem to dredge (clear out) a canal, he discovered that the muck and silt being removed could be used to help crops to grow. Impressed by his work, the government gave Kuo more and more important jobs.

Kuo discovered seashell fossils up a mountain and realized that it must have once been beside the sea.

Kuo famously dreamed about a beautiful hillside—then was shocked to stumble across it in real life! He built a house there and called it Dream Pool.